System One Models Are Not Better Rerankers

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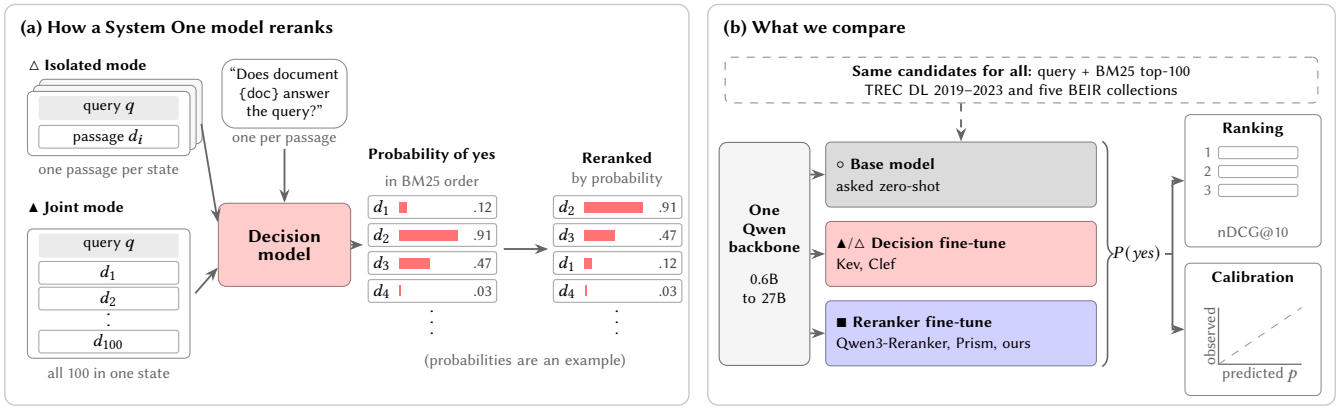


Figure 1: How System One models rerank and what we compare. (a) A decision model is asked, for each BM25 candidate, whether the passage answers the query, and the candidates are sorted by the probability of "yes". The state holds one passage (isolated mode) or all 100 candidates (joint mode). (b) On one Qwen backbone, the base model, its decision fine-tunes and its reranker fine-tunes rerank the same candidates and are compared on ranking and on calibration.

Abstract

System One models, or decision models, answer a question about an input with a calibrated probability instead of generated text. A month after the first of them was released, they are already used as rerankers. We test whether the decision fine-tuning behind them makes a better reranker than plain reranker fine-tuning of the same model. For six Qwen backbones from 0.6B to 27B parameters and ten TREC DL and BEIR collections, we compare the zero-shot base model with its decision fine-tunes and its reranker fine-tunes, one of which we train ourselves. On every backbone where both exist (0.6B to 9B), reranker fine-tuning wins, by 5 to 29 points nDCG@10, also on collections that no fine-tune was trained on. Up to 9B, decision fine-tuning adds nothing over simply asking the base model; only the largest decision model improves on its base model, and it is barely ahead of reranker fine-tunes a third of its size. The calibration that decision models are advertised for comes from the question, not from the model: asked whether a passage answers the query, they are well calibrated; asked S1Rank's looser question, the same models lose their advantage over reranker fine-tunes, and the untuned base models gain as much from the wording. Nor does calibration buy better passage selection: a reranker fine-tune keeps the better passages at a fixed threshold. If you need a reranker, fine-tune a reranker.

Keywords

Reranking, Calibration, System One Models, Decision Models, Fine-Tuning, Large Language Models

1 Introduction

Cross-encoders are a well-established way to rerank the candidates of a first-stage retriever [19, 20], and open large language models fine-tuned for ranking are the current state of the art [17, 38, 39]. *System One models*, also called decision models, promise something else. They answer a question about an input with a calibrated probability instead of generated text, in the spirit of fast, intuitive thinking [14, 33]. TypeSafe AI released the first of them, Jev, on 15 September 2026, trained with an unpublished method called RLCD (reinforcement learning for calibrated decisions) [33]. Within weeks, Jev was reported to be a competitive reranker [13, 27] and was evaluated or integrated in retrieval systems [11, 15, 34]. Open decision models followed: Kev [22] and Cloudflare's Clef [4]. They are fine-tuned from Qwen backbones, the same backbones that dedicated rerankers such as Qwen3-Reranker [39] and Prism [38] are built on.

This makes a clean test possible, and the reports so far have not run it. They compare Jev with rerankers built on other, mostly smaller models, so they cannot tell how much of its effectiveness comes from decision fine-tuning and how much from the underlying language model. Calibration does not settle the question either: any monotone transformation of the probabilities leaves a ranking

unchanged. We therefore compare decision fine-tuning with plain reranker fine-tuning of the same backbone, and we test whether the advertised calibration holds for relevance and is of any use:

RQ1 Do decision models rerank better than their base models or than reranker fine-tunes of the same backbone?

RQ2 Are their relevance probabilities better calibrated than either, and is that calibration of any use?

Figure 1 shows how a decision model reranks and what we compare. For six Qwen backbones from 0.6B to 27B parameters, we evaluate the base model asked zero-shot, its decision fine-tunes (Kev and Clef) and its reranker fine-tunes, including one we train ourselves on MS MARCO alone as a control for the undisclosed recipes of the published ones. No reranker fine-tune of the 27B backbone has been released. All of them rerank the same BM25 candidates of TREC DL 2019–2023 and five BEIR collections, and all return a probability of relevance per passage. Decision and base models are asked whether the passage answers the query; an ablation asks S1Rank's looser question instead [27]. We find:

(1) *Reranker fine-tuning beats decision fine-tuning.* From 0.6B to 9B, the reranker fine-tune ranks better on every backbone, by 5 to 29 points nDCG@10, significantly on 48 of 60 pairs of backbone and collection, never significantly worse, and also on collections that no fine-tune was trained on. At 27B, where no reranker fine-tune exists, Kev-27B is the best system in our study, but only 0.7 points ahead of reranker fine-tunes a third of its size.
(2) *Up to 9B, decision fine-tuning adds nothing over the base model.* It stays within −2.5 and +0.7 points of simply asking the untuned model the same question, while reranker fine-tuning adds 6 to 30 points. Only Kev-27B clearly improves on its base model.
(3) *The calibration advantage comes from the question, not from the model.* Asked whether a passage answers the query, decision models are well calibrated. Asked S1Rank's question, the same models lose their advantage over reranker fine-tunes while their ranking hardly moves, and the untuned base models gain as much from the wording. Calibration does not even buy better passage selection: a reranker fine-tune keeps the better set at a fixed threshold on every backbone where both exist.

If you need a reranker, fine-tune a reranker. Code, raw model outputs (a probability per query and passage) and all results are public.[1]

2 Related Work

LLM-based rerankers. Neural rerankers are trained to score query–passage pairs from relevance labels, first with encoder or sequence-to-sequence models [19, 20] and more recently with open large language models [17, 38, 39]. Qwen3-Reranker and Prism read relevance from the probability of "yes" against "no" after a prompt that asks whether the document meets the query, which makes their output directly comparable to that of a decision model. Other approaches rerank the candidates jointly, either by generating a ranked list [24, 31] or by letting passages attend to each other, as in the Set-Encoder [28]. Large language models can also rank without any reranking-specific fine-tuning, through relevance prompting [26, 40], but their effectiveness is sensitive to how the prompt is worded [30]. Abdallah et al. [1] compare many of these rerankers on the candidates we use.

Decision models in retrieval. Besides Jev [33], Kev [21, 22], Clef [4] and Laya [5] are open System One models. The evidence on decision models for retrieval is so far limited to reports that are not peer-reviewed: Jev reranking BM25 candidates [13, 15, 27], as a reranker in production search [11, 34], and the open Laya as a relevance gate before recall [5, 29]. These reports compare Jev with existing rerankers, which are built on other models. None compares decision fine-tuning with reranker fine-tuning of the same backbone, and none asks whether the calibration of the probabilities pays off.

Calibration of relevance scores. Neural networks tend to be overconfident, and temperature scaling after training is a simple remedy [12]. Neural rankers are no exception [23]. Common ranking losses are invariant to shifting the scores of a query, so rankers trained with them can order passages well without being calibrated [23, 36]; scores can be calibrated during or after training [12, 37]. Calibrated probabilities matter wherever a score is read on an absolute scale, for example to cut off a ranked list [2]. This is the use we test in RQ2.

3 Decision Models as Rerankers

A decision model takes a structured input, the *state*, together with one or more questions about it, and returns a probability for each possible answer. We use binary questions only, so every question yields one number, the probability of "yes". Reranking follows directly: for a query q with candidates $d_1, \ldots, d_k$ from a first-stage retriever, we ask about each passage d_i whether it answers q and order the passages by the returned probabilities p_i.

For the state, we consider two modes. In *isolated* mode, the state holds the query and a single passage, so that $p_i = P(yes \mid q, d_i)$. This is a pointwise reranker, like a cross-encoder. In *joint* mode, the state holds the query and all k candidates in first-stage order, and the k questions are asked about this one state, so that $p_i = P(yes \mid q, d_1, \ldots, d_k)$ can depend on the other candidates. Joint mode shares its input with listwise rerankers but returns a score per passage instead of a permutation, like the Set-Encoder [28]. Both modes are pointwise in what they output, and both are the modes of S1Rank [27].

The two alternatives have the same interface. A reranker fine-tune such as Qwen3-Reranker reads p_i from the probability of "yes" against "no" after a prompt that holds q and d_i. A base model, asked the decision models' question in its chat format, gives p_i as the probability of "yes" as its first answer token. All three variants of a backbone therefore produce a probability of relevance for every query and passage, which we can rank by (RQ1) and read on an absolute scale (RQ2).

4 Experimental Setup

Backbones and variants. We study six Qwen backbones: Qwen3-0.6B and 8B, Qwen3.5-0.8B, 4B and 9B, and Qwen3.8-27B. Each is evaluated in up to three variants (Figure 1). The *base model* is the

[1] https://github.com/KanishkaGD/decision-rerank

released model, asked the question in its chat format with thinking off and scored by the probability of "yes" as the first answer token. The *decision fine-tunes* are Kev [21, 22] (LoRA on the pretrained checkpoints up to 9B, a full fine-tune of the post-trained 27B model) and Clef-Flash (9B) and Clef (27B) [4], each run in isolated and joint mode (Sect. 3). We call them decision fine-tunes because they fine-tune an open model to give Jev's kind of output; they are not reproductions of RLCD, which is unpublished [21]. The *reranker fine-tunes* are Qwen3-Reranker [39], built on the same pretrained checkpoints as Kev, and Prism [38], both scored by the probability of "yes" against "no". No reranker fine-tune of Qwen3.8-27B has been released, so this variant is missing at 27B.

Our reranker fine-tune. As a control for the undisclosed recipes of the published rerankers, we train a reranker fine-tune of Qwen3.5-9B ourselves (*Ours-9B*), which can be compared with Prism-9B on the same backbone. This gives us one reranker fine-tune whose training data and losses we control. The recipe is public and deliberately plain: LoRA ($r = 32$) in Qwen3-Reranker's prompt format, one epoch over 100k MS MARCO training queries [18], each with one relevant passage and 15 hard negatives (eight from a dense retriever, seven from BM25), and a ranking loss (InfoNCE over the group) plus a yes/no classification loss (binary cross-entropy of every passage's score). The second term gives the model a meaningful $P(\textit{yes})$. We removed training queries that match a test or development topic and chose the checkpoint on 200 MS MARCO dev queries by a rule fixed in advance. No decision data and no hyperparameter search are involved. Qwen3-Reranker, Prism and Ours-9B saw MS MARCO in training; Kev's training data contain neither MS MARCO nor BEIR [21].

The question. Every decision and base model is asked one question per passage: "Does document `{doc}` answer the `query`?" It matches the relevance labels we evaluate against (on TREC DL, a passage counts as relevant if it answers the query, from grade 2). We fixed this question before running the experiments, but did not choose it on development data, and we report every result with it. The only other wording we ran is the question of S1Rank [27]: "Is document `{doc}` relevant to the `query`? Relevant means it answers the query or contains information that directly addresses it." It is the subject of the ablation in Sect. 7. Reranker fine-tunes ask no question of this kind; they keep their own prompt.

Collections and candidates. We use TREC DL 2019–2023 [6–10] on the MS MARCO v1 and v2 passages [18] and five BEIR collections [32]: TREC-COVID, NFCorpus, SciFact, Touché and DBPedia. None of the fine-tunes was trained on TREC-COVID, Touché or DBPedia, which form the *zero-shot subset* (ZS). Every system reranks the BM25 top-100 of Pyserini [16]; these are the candidates of S1Rank [27] and of earlier comparisons [1, 24, 31], whose published numbers we use where we did not rerun a system.

Other systems. For context, we report BM25, Jev 1.13.0 (closed, in both modes), Laya [5] (isolated only, as its context is too short for a joint state), monoT5-3B [20], bge-reranker-v2-m3 [3], the Set-Encoder [28], RankZephyr [24] (run by us on TREC DL) and RankGPT-4 [31] (published numbers only).

Ranking. We measure nDCG@10 and test differences with paired t-tests over queries, Holm-corrected across the ten collections ($p < 0.05$). Per backbone, we test the reranker fine-tune against the decision fine-tune with the best average (in its better mode), that decision fine-tune against the base model, and joint against isolated mode.

Calibration and its uses. We compute the expected calibration error (ECE, 15 equal-width bins) [12] and the Brier score (the mean squared error of the probability against the binary label, which also rewards separating relevant from non-relevant passages) on the judged query–passage pairs of TREC DL 2019–2023, the only collections that also judge many non-relevant passages; a passage counts as relevant from grade 2. We test two uses of the probabilities. A *fixed cutoff* keeps every candidate with $p \geq 0.5$; we report the F_1 of this set (unjudged passages count as non-relevant), its size, and its *regret*: the F_1 at the best threshold of each collection, chosen afterwards, minus the F_1 at 0.5. The *count* test sums a query's probabilities over its judged passages, which estimates how many of them are relevant, and reports the mean absolute error of this estimate in passages; always guessing the median count is the trivial baseline. Reranker fine-tunes are also calibrated after the fact, with temperature and Platt scaling of their logit fitted on 1,000 MS MARCO dev queries, never on a test collection.

Sanity checks. Our BM25, monoT5-3B and RankZephyr runs reproduce published numbers [1, 25] within 0.2 points nDCG@10. Jev in joint mode, asked S1Rank's question, reproduces S1Rank's numbers [27] within 0.5 points on four of five collections (1.5 below on TREC-COVID).

5 RQ1: Decision vs. Reranker Fine-Tuning

Reranker fine-tuning beats decision fine-tuning. On every backbone where both exist, from 0.6B to 9B, the reranker fine-tune ranks better than the decision fine-tune in either mode (Table 1). Averaged over the ten collections, its margin over the better decision mode ranges from 5.2 points nDCG@10 at Qwen3.5-9B (Prism-9B 59.0 vs. Clef-Flash 53.8) to 28.8 points at Qwen3-0.6B (56.1 vs. 27.3). The difference is significant on 48 of the 60 pairs of reranker fine-tune and collection, and the decision fine-tune is never significantly better (*). The margin does not come from training on MS MARCO: on the zero-shot subset, which no fine-tune was trained on, it ranges from 5.4 to 23.9 points. Nor does it come from the undisclosed recipes of the published rerankers: Ours-9B, trained on MS MARCO alone with standard losses, matches Prism-9B (59.4 vs. 59.0 on average, 56.1 vs. 53.7 on the zero-shot subset).

Up to 9B, decision fine-tuning adds nothing over the base model. Up to 9B, the better mode of a decision fine-tune stays within −2.5 and +0.7 points of its zero-shot base model, asked the same question, with significant gains on at most three of ten collections (†). Reranker fine-tuning of the same backbones adds 5.9 (Prism-9B) to 29.5 points (Qwen3-Reranker-0.6B). A user who takes the released Qwen3.5-4B or Qwen3.5-9B and asks it whether a passage answers the query gets the same ranking as from the decision fine-tunes built on it, at no training cost.

Table 1: Base model, decision fine-tunes and reranker fine-tunes of the same backbone (nDCG@10, ×100, BM25 top-100). Base and decision models are asked whether the passage answers the query. Avg: mean over all ten collections; ZS: mean over the collections without a training split in any fine-tune's data (TREC-COVID, Touché, DBPedia). Per backbone and column: best in bold, second best underlined. Training: ○ base model, ▲/△ decision fine-tune (joint/isolated), ■ reranker fine-tune (rows shaded grey, red, blue); *Ours-9B*: our reranker fine-tune. Paired t-test, Holm-corrected over the ten collections, $p < 0.05$: * reranker fine-tune vs. the decision fine-tune with the best Avg, † that decision fine-tune vs. the base model, ‡ joint vs. isolated. No reranker fine-tune of the 27B backbone has been released.

			TREC DL					BEIR					Mean	
	System	Mode	DL19	DL20	DL21	DL22	DL23	COVID	NFC	SciF	Touché	DBP	Avg	ZS
Qwen3-0.6B														
○	Qwen3-0.6B		43.3	32.7	37.7	22.1	17.9	50.9	15.1	14.2	16.8	15.3	26.6	27.7
▲	Kev-0.6B	joint	23.3‡	15.1‡	20.4‡	12.8‡	12.1‡	36.8‡	12.4‡	4.5‡	5.2‡	8.4‡	15.1	16.8
△	Kev-0.6B	isolated	35.3	30.5	40.1	22.8	19.0	55.9	16.5	15.5	14.1	22.9†	27.3	31.0
■	Qwen3-Reranker-0.6B		**69.5***	**64.0***	**65.2***	**46.4***	**38.8***	**86.2***	**36.4***	**76.6***	**35.7***	**42.7***	**56.1**	**54.9**
Qwen3-8B														
○	Qwen3-8B		67.3	63.7	62.0	38.3	39.0	77.6	32.7	73.3	25.5	31.6	51.1	44.9
▲	Kev-8B	joint	62.7	55.2	59.1	35.5	34.3	53.1‡	20.4‡	17.9‡	12.3‡	36.2‡	38.7	33.9
△	Kev-8B	isolated	69.0	63.1	61.9	38.6	36.4	80.6	33.8	69.8	25.2	39.0†	51.7	48.3
■	Qwen3-Reranker-8B		**73.2**	**66.8**	**67.0***	**51.2***	**45.2***	**84.0**	**37.3***	**79.9***	**43.1***	**46.2***	**59.4**	**57.8**
Qwen3.5-0.8B														
○	Qwen3.5-0.8B		46.0	41.2	52.1	28.1	27.9	59.2	18.3	27.0	16.4	22.3	33.9	32.6
▲	Kev-0.8B	joint	37.9	33.8	41.0	21.3	20.0	46.2‡	20.3	30.0	12.0	16.4‡	27.9	24.9
△	Kev-0.8B	isolated	41.8	38.4	47.9	24.7	23.9	68.1†	19.2	31.5	16.5	29.9†	34.2	38.2
■	Prism-0.8B		**72.3***	**67.7***	**66.3***	**47.0***	**43.7***	**84.2***	**36.1***	**76.3***	**35.6***	**41.7***	**57.1**	**53.8**
Qwen3.5-4B														
○	Qwen3.5-4B		67.9	64.0	65.9	42.3	40.4	78.0	33.3	74.1	25.0	33.0	52.4	45.3
▲	Kev-4B	joint	62.5	63.2	60.8	37.0	36.3	75.3	29.3‡	58.4‡	19.9	39.8	48.2	45.0
△	Kev-4B	isolated	62.7	62.9	60.9	37.9	34.5†	78.0	32.0	67.7†	23.4	39.0†	49.9	46.8
■	Prism-4B		**74.4***	**68.9***	**70.3***	**50.1***	**46.2***	**84.6***	**37.4***	**76.9***	**34.3***	**43.7***	**58.7**	**54.2**
Qwen3.5-9B														
○	Qwen3.5-9B		67.3	65.9	66.1	43.7	39.9	77.8	33.3	76.0	26.3	34.5	53.1	46.2
▲	Kev-9B	joint	62.2	62.3	60.5	37.7	36.5	76.8	31.4	56.0‡	23.7	36.1	48.3	45.5
△	Kev-9B	isolated	63.3	64.0	60.1	38.7	34.8	75.9	33.3	71.7	21.9	35.6	49.9	44.5
▲	Clef-Flash	joint	67.5	67.4	63.9	42.9	41.2	80.9	34.1‡	62.4‡	20.0	37.5‡	51.8	46.1
△	Clef-Flash	isolated	67.8	69.6†	64.5	43.8	43.1	80.5	36.1†	68.1†	23.4	40.8†	53.8	48.3
■	Prism-9B		**74.0***	**71.1**	**71.0***	51.6*	44.2	83.0	**37.2**	**79.8***	34.7*	43.2*	59.0	53.7
■	*Ours-9B*		73.8*	70.0	67.3	**52.1***	**47.0**	**84.2**	37.1	77.9*	**36.5***	**47.7***	**59.4**	**56.1**
Qwen3.8-27B														
○	Qwen3.8-27B		71.9	68.7	66.9	45.8	44.7	82.6	37.2	74.5	30.1	41.7	56.4	51.5
▲	Kev-27B	joint	72.8	**72.9**†	**70.7**†	**50.9**†	**49.2**†	**83.9**	**38.4**†	**81.1**†	**36.1**†	44.9†	**60.1**	**55.0**
△	Kev-27B	isolated	**73.6**	70.5	70.1	50.5	46.7	83.2	37.9	80.6	32.1	**45.2**	59.0	53.5
▲	Clef	joint	70.5	72.4	66.2	48.2	45.9	80.7	35.6	58.7	29.2	40.9	54.8	50.3
△	Clef	isolated	69.4	68.5	66.5	43.7	43.3	80.3	36.2	62.7	28.1	40.5	53.9	49.6

27B: the one place where decision fine-tuning helps. The largest backbone is the exception. Kev-27B improves on its base model by 3.7 points (60.1 vs. 56.4), significantly on eight collections, and is the best system in our study. Clef, the other 27B decision fine-tune, adds nothing (54.8 joint, 53.9 isolated). No reranker fine-tune of this backbone has been released, so the comparison of RQ1 is open at 27B. Kev-27B is, however, only 0.7 points ahead of reranker fine-tunes a third of its size (Qwen3-Reranker-8B and Ours-9B, 59.4), and if reranker fine-tuning added as much at 27B as on the smaller backbones (5.9 points or more), a 27B reranker fine-tune would be ahead of it.

Context. Table 2 places the triplets among other rerankers on the same candidates. Jev (59.1) ranks as well as the reranker fine-tunes of 8B and 9B (59.0 to 59.4) and the Set-Encoder (59.0). The open Kev-27B (60.1) matches the closed model it imitates: there is no secret in Jev that an open fine-tune of a strong backbone cannot reach. Laya (43.5) does not improve on its BM25 candidates (43.2).

Joint scoring helps only the largest models. Scoring all candidates in one state gains about one point for Kev-27B (60.1 vs. 59.0) and Clef (54.8 vs. 53.9), but costs Kev-0.6B 12.2 points and Kev-8B 13.0 (‡; significant on all ten and on five collections). A likely reason is the length of the state. A joint state of 100 passages has about 13k tokens on TREC DL and 40k or more on BEIR, whereas Kev-0.8B and Kev-4B were trained on states of at most 7,552 tokens, and Kev-27B on states of up to 32,768 [21].

6 RQ2: Are Decision Models at Least Better Calibrated?

Calibration is the main promise of decision models. Table 3 reports it on the judged pairs of TREC DL 2019–2023, together with the two uses we test.

Asked our question, decision models are well calibrated. The untuned base models of 0.6B and 0.8B parameters say "yes" to almost everything (ECE 0.750 and 0.617); from 4B on, they are reasonably calibrated already (0.117 to 0.231). On the small backbones, fine-tuning of either kind improves on the base model, reranker

Table 2: Context: other rerankers (nDCG@10, ×100) on the BM25 top-100 of TREC DL 2019–2023 and five BEIR collections; System One models in joint mode (Laya isolated), asked whether the passage answers the query (Sect. 4). †: published number on the same candidates [1, 35], not recomputed. Avg: mean over all ten collections (only where all are available). $/1k: mean API cost in US dollars per 1,000 queries over the collections run. Best reranker per column in bold.

		TREC DL					BEIR						
System	Mode	DL19	DL20	DL21	DL22	DL23	COVID	NFC	SciF	Touché	DBP	Avg	$/1k
BM25		50.6	48.0	44.6	26.9	26.2	59.5	32.2	67.9	44.2	31.8	43.2	–
Listwise LLM rerankers													
RankGPT-4		**75.6**†	70.6†	–	–	–	**85.5**†	38.5†	75.0†	38.6†	**47.1**†	–	–
RankZephyr-7B		74.3	70.0	67.9	50.5	44.1	80.7†	36.6†	75.1†	31.1†	43.2†	57.3	–
Cross-encoders and LLM rerankers													
bge-reranker-v2-m3		72.2†	67.0†	66.1	51.5	45.1	74.8†	33.8†	73.5†	39.9†	41.9†	56.6	–
monoT5-3B		71.8	68.9	66.7	49.5	45.0	80.7†	**39.0**†	76.6†	32.4†	44.5†	57.5	–
Qwen3-Reranker-8B		73.2	66.8	67.0	51.2	45.2	84.0	37.3	79.9	**43.1**	46.2	59.4	–
Set-Encoder-large		75.0†	72.2†	69.9	**53.4**	47.7	81.2	36.8	73.8	33.2	47.0	59.0	–
System One models													
Jev	joint	73.0	70.9	**70.7**	50.3	46.1	83.3	37.8	80.3	33.5	45.5	59.1	1.11
Clef-Flash	joint	67.5	67.4	63.9	42.9	41.2	80.9	34.1	62.4	20.0	37.5	51.8	–
Clef	joint	70.5	72.4	66.2	48.2	45.9	80.7	35.6	58.7	29.2	40.9	54.8	–
Kev-4B	joint	62.5	63.2	60.8	37.0	36.3	75.3	29.3	58.4	19.9	39.8	48.2	–
Kev-27B	joint	72.8	**72.9**	**70.7**	50.9	**49.2**	83.9	38.4	**81.1**	36.1	44.9	**60.1**	–
Laya	isolated	59.5	54.6	52.8	35.3	32.7	73.8	28.7	44.8	21.8	31.3	43.5	–

Table 3: Calibration and its uses on the judged pairs of TREC DL 2019–2023 (means). Per foundation model: base model, decision fine-tunes in their better-calibrated mode (j/i: joint/isolated), reranker fine-tunes. ECE (lower is better): N native; T, P after temperature/Platt scaling fitted on MS MARCO dev (rerankers only). Brier: mean squared error of the probability. F_1@.5 (×100): set kept at $p \geq 0.5$, native (N) and Platt-scaled (P); Regret: F_1 at each collection's best cutoff minus F_1@.5; $|S|$: passages kept at 0.5 (of 100). Count: mean absolute error of the summed probabilities against the number of relevant passages (always guessing the median count: 8.6). Per foundation model and column: best in bold, second best underlined.

		ECE				F_1@.5				
	System	N	T	P	Brier	N	P	Regret	$\|S\|$	Count
Qwen3-0.6B										
○	Qwen3-0.6B	0.750	–	–	0.750	19.9	–	**0.5**	100.0	36.5
△	Kev-0.6B (i)	**0.503**	–	–	**0.463**	21.4	–	2.2	79.8	**24.7**
■	Qwen3-Reranker-0.6B	0.511	**0.326**	**0.226**	0.481	**31.8**	**6.3**	14.9	58.4	24.8
Qwen3-8B										
○	Qwen3-8B	0.231	–	–	0.233	42.5	–	**2.1**	22.9	8.7
▲	Kev-8B (j)	**0.113**	–	–	**0.177**	34.0	–	3.1	13.7	**7.6**
■	Qwen3-Reranker-8B	0.257	**0.237**	**0.227**	0.238	**46.3**	**7.4**	9.0	32.2	12.9
Qwen3.5-0.8B										
○	Qwen3.5-0.8B	0.617	–	–	0.566	21.6	–	11.2	88.8	29.9
△	Kev-0.8B (i)	0.336	–	–	0.297	25.1	–	2.9	51.9	16.9
■	Prism-0.8B	**0.243**	**0.229**	**0.237**	**0.193**	**46.9**	**5.7**	**2.8**	26.5	**12.7**
Other systems										
▲	Jev (j)	**0.075**	–	–	**0.127**	**54.7**	–	1.7	16.0	**6.3**
△	Laya	0.127	–	–	0.183	37.5	–	**1.0**	23.3	9.2
■	monoT5-3B	0.312	0.257	**0.232**	0.295	42.0	**5.8**	9.9	35.6	15.2
■	bge-reranker-v2-m3	0.231	**0.226**	0.236	0.228	48.2	5.7	3.8	29.3	12.1
■	Set-Encoder-large	0.495	0.250	0.236	0.426	31.6	5.7	21.1	52.2	24.3

		ECE				F_1@.5				
	System	N	T	P	Brier	N	P	Regret	$\|S\|$	Count
Qwen3.5-4B										
○	Qwen3.5-4B	0.181	–	–	0.195	44.3	–	3.1	27.1	9.8
△	Kev-4B (i)	**0.132**	–	–	0.175	42.6	–	**1.4**	21.9	**8.4**
■	Prism-4B	0.218	**0.202**	**0.238**	**0.172**	**51.0**	**5.7**	2.8	23.1	11.5
Qwen3.5-9B										
○	Qwen3.5-9B	0.165	–	–	0.181	46.5	–	2.9	24.4	8.7
▲	Kev-9B (j)	0.160	–	–	0.177	40.2	–	2.3	23.8	9.5
▲	Clef-Flash (j)	0.112	–	–	0.158	47.1	–	**1.7**	18.9	8.1
■	Prism-9B	0.242	0.233	0.238	0.183	**50.7**	5.7	4.0	26.0	12.3
■	*Ours-9B*	**0.111**	**0.108**	**0.231**	**0.157**	46.6	**6.9**	6.4	8.7	**7.3**
Qwen3.8-27B										
○	Qwen3.8-27B	0.117	–	–	0.144	54.1	–	1.9	16.0	**5.8**
▲	Kev-27B (j)	**0.076**	–	–	**0.130**	**57.2**	–	**0.9**	16.1	6.0
▲	Clef (j)	0.091	–	–	0.139	53.4	–	2.2	17.7	6.7

fine-tuning as much as decision fine-tuning (0.6B: Kev 0.503, Qwen3-Reranker 0.511; 0.8B: Kev 0.336, Prism 0.243). From 4B on, the decision fine-tunes are better calibrated than the published reranker fine-tunes (ECE: Kev-4B 0.132 vs. Prism-4B 0.218, Kev-8B 0.113 vs. Qwen3-Reranker-8B 0.257, Clef-Flash 0.112 vs. Prism-9B 0.242). The best calibrated systems in the study are Jev (0.075) and Kev-27B (0.076). Decision fine-tuning is not the only way there: our 9B reranker fine-tune, which asks no question and was trained with a plain yes/no loss, is as well calibrated as Clef-Flash (0.111 vs. 0.112) and has the lower Brier score (0.157 vs. 0.158).

The advantage comes from the question. All of this holds for a question that matches the relevance labels. Section 7 repeats every run with S1Rank's looser question: the same decision models then lose their advantage over the reranker fine-tunes, while their ranking hardly moves. The calibration of a decision model is a property of the question it is asked.

Calibration does not buy better passage selection. If every passage with $p \geq 0.5$ is kept, a reranker fine-tune keeps the better set on every backbone where both exist (e.g. F_1@.5 of 51.0 for Prism-4B vs. 42.6 for Kev-4B, and 50.7 for Prism-9B vs. 47.1 for Clef-Flash), although it is the worse calibrated model on most of them. For the decision models, 0.5 is close to the best threshold of each collection (regret of 0.9 to 3.1 points), whereas Prism-9B loses 4.0 points and

Ours-9B 6.4 against their best thresholds. A well-placed threshold on a worse ranking still yields the worse set.

Counting relevant passages. The count test asks how many of a query's judged passages are relevant, which a ranking cannot tell. Most decision models from 4B on beat always guessing the median count (8.6) and the published reranker fine-tunes of their backbones (Kev-8B 7.6 vs. Qwen3-Reranker-8B 12.9, Kev-4B 8.4 vs. Prism-4B 11.5). The untuned Qwen3.8-27B counts most accurately of all (5.8), and Ours-9B counts better than Clef-Flash (7.3 vs. 8.1): counting works with a matching question, with or without decision fine-tuning.

Calibration after the fact. Rerankers can also be calibrated after training. Temperature scaling fitted on MS MARCO dev lowers the ECE of the worst calibrated rerankers on TREC DL (Qwen3-Reranker-0.6B from 0.511 to 0.326, the Set-Encoder from 0.495 to 0.250) and changes the others little. Platt scaling makes every reranker worse at the fixed cutoff (F_1@.5 of 7.4 or less): MS MARCO dev judges about one passage per query, so the fitted probabilities are far too low for the denser judgments of TREC DL. Calibration is defined only with respect to a notion of relevance and its base rate (Sect. 8).

7 Ablation: The Wording Decides

Decision models are sold as models one can simply ask. So far we asked them one question, whether the passage answers the query. Table 4 repeats every run of a decision or base model with the question of S1Rank [27]. It asks whether the passage is relevant and defines relevance more loosely: the passage "answers the query or contains information that directly addresses it". Both wordings are reasonable, and S1Rank's is the one under which Jev was first shown to be a good reranker.

Ranking hardly moves. The mean nDCG@10 of the decision fine-tunes changes by −2.5 to +2.6 points between the two questions (Jev joint 60.5 with S1Rank's question vs. 59.1 with ours, Kev-27B joint 61.1 vs. 60.1). The answer to RQ1 does not depend on the wording: with S1Rank's question, too, the best decision fine-tune of every backbone up to 9B is 4 points or more behind the reranker fine-tune.

Calibration moves a lot. The ECE drops for almost every model when it is asked our question, often by a factor of two or three: Jev joint from 0.224 to 0.075, Kev-8B joint from 0.243 to 0.113, Kev-27B joint from 0.156 to 0.076. The count error moves with it (Jev joint from 11.3 to 6.3 passages). Asked S1Rank's question, the decision fine-tunes are at best as well calibrated as the best reranker fine-tune of their backbone (Table 3): Kev-4B 0.216 vs. Prism-4B 0.218, Kev-8B 0.243 vs. Qwen3-Reranker-8B 0.257, Clef-Flash 0.140 vs. Ours-9B 0.111. No decision model then beats the median guess in the count test by more than a fraction of a passage (Clef joint 8.4 vs. 8.6). One sentence of the prompt decides the answer to RQ2.

The base models move as much. The untuned models gain as much from the wording as the decision fine-tunes (Qwen3-8B from 0.383 to 0.231, Qwen3.5-9B from 0.283 to 0.165). What makes the probabilities calibrated is a question that matches the definition of relevance in the labels, not decision fine-tuning. The user of a decision model has to put that definition into words, and a small change in the words changes the calibration severalfold. A reranker fine-tune has no such knob: its notion of relevance is fixed by its training labels.

8 Discussion and Limitations

Why decision fine-tuning does not make a reranker. A reranker fine-tune is trained on the very task it is tested on: telling relevant from non-relevant passages of a query, with a ranking loss over hard negatives. The decision fine-tunes we tested learned to answer many kinds of questions about many kinds of states, and Kev's training data contain no MS MARCO and no BEIR [21]. That general skill transfers to relevance about as well as the base model's own instruction following, which is what we observe up to 9B. The zero-shot subset shows that the gap is not about having seen the test domain: it persists on collections that neither kind of fine-tune was trained on.

What calibration means for relevance. A probability of relevance is calibrated only with respect to a definition of relevance and its base rate. Our results show three ways to move it: the wording of the question (Sect. 7), the labels of the training data (our reranker fine-tune) and the labels a scaling is fitted on (Platt scaling on MS MARCO dev, Sect. 6). A model that is "calibrated out of the box" is calibrated against a notion of relevance that someone chose, and the user of a decision model has to put that notion into words. For ranking none of this matters; for a threshold or a count it matters a lot.

Limitations. We compare released models, and the fine-tunes of a backbone differ in their training data as well as in their objective. Our results therefore describe decision fine-tuning as it is available today, not RLCD as such, which is unpublished and may be done better. Our own reranker fine-tune, the control for the published recipes, was trained once, with one recipe and without any hyperparameter search. At 27B, where Kev is the best system, no reranker fine-tune exists for comparison. We measured calibration only on TREC DL, where non-relevant passages are judged, and at a single relevance grade and a single threshold. Our question was fixed before the runs but not chosen on development data, and we tried only one other wording. All decision models are at most a month old, and newer versions may change the picture; we release all raw outputs so that the comparison can be repeated.

9 Conclusion

System One models are not better rerankers. On every backbone where both exist, plain reranker fine-tuning beats decision fine-tuning, by 5 to 29 points nDCG@10 from 0.6B to 9B, and up to 9B decision fine-tuning adds nothing over simply asking the base model. Only at 27B, where no reranker fine-tune exists, does a decision model stand out, and it is barely ahead of reranker fine-tunes a third of its size. The calibration that decision models are advertised for comes from the question, not from the model: a question that matches the relevance labels makes decision and base models alike much better calibrated, a looser one takes the advantage away, and either way calibration does not buy better passage selection. If you need a reranker, fine-tune a reranker.

Table 4: The question ablation: S1Rank's question (*Rel.*: "Is document {doc} relevant to the query? Relevant means it answers the query or contains information that directly addresses it.") against the question used in the rest of the paper (*Ans.*: "Does document {doc} answer the query?"), for every system that is asked a question. nDCG@10 (×100): mean over all ten collections (Avg) and over TREC DL 2019–2023 (DL); ECE and Count as in Table 3 (DL 2019–2023). Δ: Ans. minus Rel. Training: ○ base model, ▲/△ decision fine-tune (joint/isolated), ■ reranker fine-tune.

			nDCG@10 Avg			nDCG@10 DL			ECE			Count		
	System	Mode	Rel.	Ans.	Δ	Rel.	Ans.	Δ	Rel.	Ans.	Δ	Rel.	Ans.	Δ
Qwen3-0.6B														
○	Qwen3-0.6B		23.8	26.6	+2.8	25.4	30.7	+5.3	0.750	0.750	0.000	36.5	36.5	0.0
▲	Kev-0.6B	joint	13.2	15.1	+1.9	14.9	16.7	+1.8	0.591	0.503	−0.088	28.8	24.6	−4.2
△	Kev-0.6B	isolated	27.0	27.3	+0.3	28.8	29.5	+0.7	0.579	0.503	−0.076	28.2	24.7	−3.5
Qwen3-8B														
○	Qwen3-8B		53.3	51.1	−2.2	56.9	54.0	−2.9	0.383	0.231	−0.152	17.5	8.7	−8.8
▲	Kev-8B	joint	38.8	38.7	−0.1	50.9	49.3	−1.6	0.243	0.113	−0.130	12.8	7.6	−5.2
△	Kev-8B	isolated	52.7	51.7	−1.0	54.2	53.8	−0.4	0.283	0.154	−0.129	14.1	8.7	−5.4
Qwen3.5-0.8B														
○	Qwen3.5-0.8B		37.6	33.9	−3.7	40.3	39.1	−1.2	0.716	0.617	−0.099	34.8	29.9	−4.9
▲	Kev-0.8B	joint	25.3	27.9	+2.6	28.9	30.8	+1.9	0.395	0.398	+0.003	19.5	19.6	+0.1
△	Kev-0.8B	isolated	36.0	34.2	−1.8	36.1	35.3	−0.8	0.357	0.336	−0.021	18.0	16.9	−1.1
Qwen3.5-4B														
○	Qwen3.5-4B		52.7	52.4	−0.3	55.8	56.1	+0.3	0.296	0.181	−0.115	14.7	9.8	−4.9
▲	Kev-4B	joint	49.8	48.2	−1.6	53.4	51.9	−1.5	0.251	0.201	−0.050	13.2	11.6	−1.6
△	Kev-4B	isolated	51.3	49.9	−1.4	52.7	51.8	−0.9	0.216	0.132	−0.084	11.5	8.4	−3.1
Qwen3.5-9B														
○	Qwen3.5-9B		53.7	53.1	−0.6	56.7	56.6	−0.1	0.283	0.165	−0.118	14.1	8.7	−5.4
▲	Kev-9B	joint	50.2	48.3	−1.9	54.0	51.9	−2.1	0.237	0.160	−0.077	12.2	9.5	−2.7
△	Kev-9B	isolated	50.1	49.9	−0.2	52.8	52.2	−0.6	0.348	0.221	−0.127	16.9	11.8	−5.1
▲	Clef-Flash	joint	52.8	51.8	−1.0	57.0	56.6	−0.4	0.140	0.112	−0.028	8.9	8.1	−0.8
△	Clef-Flash	isolated	54.7	53.8	−0.9	58.9	57.8	−1.1	0.173	0.144	−0.029	9.7	8.2	−1.5
Qwen3.8-27B														
○	Qwen3.8-27B		57.4	56.4	−1.0	59.9	59.6	−0.3	0.166	0.117	−0.049	8.9	5.8	−3.1
▲	Kev-27B	joint	61.1	60.1	−1.0	63.5	63.3	−0.2	0.156	0.076	−0.080	8.5	6.0	−2.5
△	Kev-27B	isolated	59.8	59.0	−0.8	62.5	62.3	−0.2	0.262	0.180	−0.082	12.9	9.4	−3.5
▲	Clef	joint	56.1	54.8	−1.3	61.1	60.6	−0.5	0.147	0.091	−0.056	8.4	6.7	−1.7
△	Clef	isolated	56.4	53.9	−2.5	58.5	58.3	−0.2	0.240	0.153	−0.087	12.1	8.3	−3.8
Other systems														
▲	Jev	joint	60.5	59.1	−1.4	62.7	62.2	−0.5	0.224	0.075	−0.149	11.3	6.3	−5.0
△	Jev	isolated	59.5	57.1	−2.4	61.4	60.0	−1.4	0.260	0.125	−0.135	12.9	7.8	−5.1
△	Laya	isolated	44.0	43.5	−0.5	47.3	47.0	−0.3	0.131	0.127	−0.004	9.3	9.2	−0.1

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